

Following the division of the Democrats, a new coalition and rival faction came together in Baltimore. The Constitutional Union Party was made up of conservative ex-Whigs and men from the Border States who opposed disunion. By ignoring the issue of slavery they appealed to the Southern residents of Tennessee, Virginia, and Kentucky who threw their support behind them. The party's presidential nominee, John Bell of Tennessee, promised to abide by the Constitution and preserve the Union.

A vicious campaign ensued. In traditional election spirit, public speakers and political newspapers attacked and defamed their opponents using sectional language and personal insults.

Douglas traveled the country warning against disunion, despite facing hostile crowds and accusations of drunkenness. Racial epithets were flung at the Republicans, who were called advocates of Black American equality and mixing of the races. Lincoln's running mate, the swarthy senator from Maine, Hannibal Hamlin, was often described as a mulatto. John Breckinridge faced shouts of "traitor" and "destroyer of the Union," while Bell was characterized as the leader of an elderly and irrelevant faction.